Feelings & reactions

A conversational idiom workbook: 8 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **get sick of**: To become tired of something or someone because you have had too much of it.
2. **a hard pill to swallow**: A fact or piece of news that is difficult or upsetting to accept.
3. **hot under the collar**: Angry or annoyed, often over something small.
4. **I could get used to this**: I like this a lot and would be happy if it happened all the time.
5. **not feeling it**: You have no energy, mood or motivation to do something.
6. **put up with**: To accept something annoying without complaining or leaving.
7. **take it in stride**: To accept a problem calmly without getting upset.
8. **under your breath**: In a very quiet voice, so other people cannot hear well.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

get sick of

Expression | Level B1 | Casual

To become tired of something or someone because you have had too much of it.

Tip: Use 'get sick of' + noun or -ing (get sick of waiting); it shows real frustration, so save it for informal talk and avoid it with someone you don't know well.

Diego: Are you still eating the same lunch every day?

Mei: Yes, chicken salad. It's quick, and I don't have time to cook.

Diego: Aren't you bored of it by now?

Mei: Honestly, I'm about to get sick of it. I might try the new noodle place tomorrow.

Diego: Good idea. I'll come with you.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'get sick of' mean?

- ○ A. Stop liking a place because it is too expensive
- ○ B. Feel ill after eating something
- ○ C. Feel tired of something because you've had too much of it
- ○ D. Become worried that something is unhealthy

2. Fill the gap

My neighbour plays loud music every night, and I'm starting to _____ it.

3. Choose the best reply

Ken: *You've been looking for a flat for three months now. How's it going?*

- ○ A. Fine. I'm getting sick of the new flat, so I love it.
- ○ B. Not great. I'm getting sick of viewing places that are too small or too expensive.
- ○ C. Not great. I get sick of my flat because I have a bad cold.

4. Your turn: speak

Is there a daily routine or habit that you have got tired of? Tell me about it.

_____

_____

_____

a hard pill to swallow

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

A fact or piece of news that is difficult or upsetting to accept.

Tip: Say 'X was a hard pill to swallow' about news or a result you had to accept, not about a person; it often follows a disappointment, and you can add 'but' to show you have moved on.

Amira: Did you hear back from the housing office about your flat?

Kofi: Yes. They're knocking the building down next spring, so everyone has to move out.

Amira: Oh no. After six years there?

Kofi: I know. It's a hard pill to swallow, honestly. I really loved that place.

Amira: I'm sorry. Do you want help looking at new apartments this weekend?

Kofi: That would be great. Thanks.

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'a hard pill to swallow' mean?

- ○ A. News that is difficult and upsetting to accept
- ○ B. Something that is very expensive to pay for
- ○ C. A problem that is difficult to explain to other people
- ○ D. A medicine that is hard to take when you are ill

6. Fill the gap

Finding out the project had been cancelled after months of overtime was _____ for the whole team.

7. Choose the best reply

Ken: *They told me my flight home has been cancelled and I can't get another one until Monday.*

- ○ A. I hope you remember to swallow the pill with some water.
- ○ B. Great, a hard pill to swallow means you'll have a lovely weekend!
- ○ C. That's a hard pill to swallow, especially after such a long trip.

8. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you received news you didn't want to hear. How did you react?

_____

_____

_____

hot under the collar

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

Angry or annoyed, often over something small.

Tip: Use it with get or be ("he gets hot under the collar"), usually about a person's reaction to something minor; it sounds odd for serious anger.

Amira: Did you see Ken's reply to the group email about the meeting room?

Diego: I did. All we asked was whether he could swap rooms on Thursday.

Amira: I know. He got really hot under the collar about it.

Diego: Maybe he's just stressed. He has that deadline on Friday.

Amira: True. I'll bring him a coffee and say sorry for the short notice.

Diego: Good idea. That should calm things down.

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "hot under the collar" mean?

- ○ A. Very tired after working under pressure
- ○ B. Annoyed or angry, even though the reason seems small
- ○ C. Feeling too warm because the room is uncomfortable
- ○ D. Nervous and embarrassed in front of other people

10. Fill the gap

Olena always gets a bit _____ when the train is late, but it passes quickly.

11. Choose the best reply

Mei: *Why did Kofi leave the shop so quickly?*

- ○ A. He felt hot under the collar after he bought a new jacket.
- ○ B. He was hot under the collar because the shop was crowded and warm.
- ○ C. He got hot under the collar when they wouldn't accept his coupon.

12. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you or someone you know got annoyed over something small.

_____

_____

_____

I could get used to this

Expression | Level B1 | Casual

I like this a lot and would be happy if it happened all the time.

Tip: Say it when you enjoy something new and wish it could be normal; it's often a light, slightly joking comment, and it's followed by 'this' or 'it', not by a noun.

Amira: How was your first week working from the new office?

Kofi: Honestly, great. It's a ten-minute walk, and there's a café downstairs.

Amira: That's a big change from your two-hour commute.

Kofi: I know. I got home at six yesterday and still had energy to cook. I could get used to this.

Amira: Just don't get too comfortable. Wait until the rain starts!

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "I could get used to this" mean?

- ○ A. I'm not sure I can handle this change.
- ○ B. I find this difficult, but I'm slowly learning to accept it.
- ○ C. I'm enjoying this and would be happy if it continued.
- ○ D. I have done this many times before, so it feels normal.

14. Fill the gap

A hot shower, a quiet house and no emails until Monday? Yes, I _____.

15. Choose the best reply

Olena: *Ken has just booked us seats in the front row, with free snacks and extra legroom.*

- ○ A. Wow, I could get used to this!
- ○ B. I could get used to this, so please change the seats.
- ○ C. I got used to this, so I'm not interested now.

16. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when something in your daily life suddenly became easier or more comfortable.

_____

_____

_____

not feeling it

Expression | Level B1 | Casual

You have no energy, mood or motivation to do something.

Tip: Say 'I'm not feeling it' (or 'she's not feeling it') when you lack the mood or energy for something; it's casual, so use it with friends and colleagues, not in a formal email.

Kofi: Are you still coming to the gym with us after work?

Amira: I don't think so. I've had such a long day.

Kofi: Come on, you said you'd go this week.

Amira: I know, and I wanted to. But I'm really not feeling it tonight.

Kofi: Fair enough. We'll go on Thursday instead, then.

Amira: Perfect. I'll be much more energetic by then.

17. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'not feeling it' mean?

- ○ A. Amira feels too embarrassed to go to the gym.
- ○ B. Amira has no energy or motivation to go to the gym tonight.
- ○ C. Amira doesn't like Kofi's idea of going to the gym.
- ○ D. Amira can't feel any physical pain when she exercises.

18. Fill the gap

I planned to tidy my room this afternoon, but honestly I'm _____ .

19. Choose the best reply

Diego: *Do you want to go out and see a film tonight?*

- ○ A. Yes, I'm not feeling it. Let's go at eight.
- ○ B. No, I can't feel it. My hands are too cold.
- ○ C. Maybe not. I've had a busy week and I'm just not feeling it.

20. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you had plans but didn't have the energy or mood to do them.

_____

_____

_____

put up with

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To accept something annoying without complaining or leaving.

Tip: Use 'put up with' + noun or -ing (put up with the delay, put up with waiting); it often shows that something is annoying, and it is common in negative sentences and questions with 'how'.

Amira: Are you still living with those flatmates from the ad?

Kofi: Yes, but I'm looking for a new place. They leave dirty dishes everywhere.

Amira: Ugh. Why don't you just tell them to stop?

Kofi: I did, twice. Nothing changed. I've had enough.

Amira: I don't know how you've put up with it for so long.

Kofi: Me neither. My lease ends in March, so I'm counting the days.

21. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "put up with" mean?

- ○ A. To tidy up a place that someone else has made messy
- ○ B. To accept something annoying and not leave or complain
- ○ C. To offer someone a room to stay in for a while
- ○ D. To fix a problem by speaking to the people responsible

22. Fill the gap

My neighbour practises the drums every evening, and I'm not sure how much longer I can _____ it.

23. Choose the best reply

Olena: *The train is delayed again, and it's so crowded in the mornings.*

- ○ A. I know. Let's put up with the platform and wait there.
- ○ B. I know. I don't think I can put up with this commute much longer.
- ○ C. I know. I'm going to put up with a new seat on the train.

24. Your turn: speak

Is there something at work, at school or at home that you have had to put up with? Tell me about it.

_____

_____

_____

take it in stride

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To accept a problem calmly without getting upset.

Tip: Use it as 'take + it/something + in stride' for a setback or surprise, e.g. 'She took the delay in stride'; the phrase is common in American English and also well understood in British English.

Amira: Did you hear? The landlord is doubling the work on our flat, so we'll have builders here all month.

Kofi: Oh no. That sounds really stressful. How are you feeling about it?

Amira: Honestly, I'm fine. I'll just work from the library until it's done.

Kofi: You're taking it in stride. I'd be complaining to everyone I know.

Amira: I did that for the first hour, then I decided it wasn't helping.

Kofi: Fair enough. Let me know if you need a quiet desk at my office.

25. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'taking it in stride' mean?

- ○ A. Pretending a problem does not exist
- ○ B. Asking other people to solve a problem for you
- ○ C. Dealing with a problem calmly without getting upset
- ○ D. Walking slowly while thinking about a problem

26. Fill the gap

The train was an hour late, but Ravi just _____ and answered some emails on his phone.

27. Choose the best reply

Olena: *I'm so sorry, I broke your mug while I was washing up.*

- ○ A. It's fine, I took it in stride yesterday and you can take it in stride tomorrow.
- ○ B. Thanks, I always take it in stride when people are kind.
- ○ C. Don't worry about it. I've got plenty of mugs.

28. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when something went wrong and you stayed calm about it. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

under your breath

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

In a very quiet voice, so other people cannot hear well.

Tip: Use it after a verb of speaking, such as say, mutter, mumble or swear: 'She muttered something under her breath.' It usually suggests the person is annoyed or doesn't want to be heard, so don't use it for friendly whispering.

Olena: Did you see Kofi's face when the manager changed the deadline again?

Ken: I did. He smiled, but he was saying something under his breath the whole time.

Olena: Could you hear what it was?

Ken: Not really. I was standing too far away, but it didn't look polite.

Olena: Well, I don't blame him. That's the third change this week.

29. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "under your breath" mean?

- ○ A. In a very quiet voice, so others can't hear clearly
- ○ B. In a loud, angry voice so everyone can hear
- ○ C. Very quickly, without stopping to think
- ○ D. While holding your breath and not speaking at all

30. Fill the gap

My neighbour kept complaining _____ while we waited in the long queue at the post office.

31. Choose the best reply

Amira: *You looked annoyed in the meeting. Did you say something to Diego?*

- ○ A. Yes, I shouted it under my breath so the whole room could hear me.
- ○ B. No, I only muttered something under my breath. I didn't want to start an argument.
- ○ C. No, I was sitting under my breath, so I couldn't speak to him.

32. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you were annoyed but didn't want to show it. What did you do?

Answer key

get sick of

1. C. Feel tired of something because you've had too much of it
2. get sick of
3. B. Not great. I'm getting sick of viewing places that are too small or too expensive.
4. Example: Yes, I used to take the same crowded train to work every morning, and I really got sick of it. It took an hour each way and I was always standing. So I started cycling instead, and I feel much better now.

a hard pill to swallow

5. A. News that is difficult and upsetting to accept
6. a hard pill to swallow
7. C. That's a hard pill to swallow, especially after such a long trip.
8. Example: A few years ago I found out that my favourite teacher was leaving our school halfway through the year. It was a hard pill to swallow because I'd really been enjoying her classes. In the end I wrote her a thank-you card and tried to focus on the rest of the term.

hot under the collar

9. B. Annoyed or angry, even though the reason seems small
10. hot under the collar
11. C. He got hot under the collar when they wouldn't accept his coupon.
12. Example: My cousin got really hot under the collar last month when a delivery arrived an hour late. It was only a parcel of books, but he had planned his whole afternoon around it. Looking back, he laughed about it, but at the time he was quite upset.

I could get used to this

13. C. I'm enjoying this and would be happy if it continued.
14. could get used to this
15. A. Wow, I could get used to this!
16. Example: Last year my company let us work from home two days a week. I saved so much time on travel that I started exercising in the mornings, and I felt much more relaxed. I could get used to that kind of schedule.

not feeling it

17. B. Amira has no energy or motivation to go to the gym tonight.
18. not feeling it
19. C. Maybe not. I've had a busy week and I'm just not feeling it.
20. Example: Last weekend I'd arranged to go hiking with friends, but I'd slept badly all week. When the day came, I was just not feeling it, so I stayed home and rested. My friends understood, and we went the following Saturday instead.

put up with

21. B. To accept something annoying and not leave or complain
22. put up with
23. B. I know. I don't think I can put up with this commute much longer.
24. Example: At my last job, I had to put up with a very long commute for almost two years. It was tiring, but I needed the salary, so I just accepted it. Now I work closer to home, and I'm much happier.

take it in stride

25. C. Dealing with a problem calmly without getting upset
26. took it in stride
27. C. Don't worry about it. I've got plenty of mugs.
28. Example: Last summer my suitcase didn't arrive when I landed in Lisbon. I was a bit annoyed at first, but I took it in stride and bought a few basics while the airline looked for it. It turned up two days later, and I'm glad I didn't spoil the trip by worrying.

under your breath

29. A. In a very quiet voice, so others can't hear clearly
30. under her breath
31. B. No, I only muttered something under my breath. I didn't want to start an argument.
32. Example: Last month my train was cancelled for the second time in a week, and I was already late for work. I didn't want to make a scene at the station, so I just said a few unhappy words under my breath and went to find another route.